

THE SUBSTRATE STARTER KIT

Name what your character is protecting — in one sitting.

Psychologist Alfred Adler argued that personality isn't built from pleasure-seeking. It's built from compensation — the strategies a person develops to address a felt wound. Over time, the strategy becomes the personality. The behavior is no longer a response to the wound. It's simply who the person is.

Fiction works the same way. Every character worth remembering has a line they tell themselves — a sentence that justifies who they are and what they do, repeated so many times it no longer sounds like a defense. Walter White's was, "I did it for my family." Underneath the line is what it's protecting. Underneath that is the substrate: the wound the entire personality was built to compensate for.

This worksheet gets you three fields deep on one character. Fifteen focused minutes, one character, one sentence you didn't have when you sat down.

THE SHAPE YOU'RE EXCAVATING

Wound → Compensation → Personality

A felt insufficiency (wound) generates a behavioral strategy (compensation) that calcifies into what the reader experiences as the character (personality). All three layers are present in strong fiction, even if only the third is visible on the page. The fields below work backward — from the visible personality, down to the wound underneath it.

FIELD 1 Your Character's Line

What is the sentence — or the belief, or the story — your character tells themselves to justify who they are and what they do? It doesn't have to be dramatic. Write it in their voice, not yours. The line they would say, do say, throughout your manuscript, and believe completely.

EXAMPLE · Elena Vargas, former high school principal

"I had to resign because I was protecting my students from a broken system."

My character's name:

The line they tell themselves:

FIELD 2 What It's Protecting

Every defended line protects something — a self-image, a decision that can't be undone, an identity that collapses if the line stops holding. Don't answer analytically. Ask: if the line were stripped away, and your character had to sit quietly, alone, without it — what would be waiting there?

EXAMPLE · Elena Vargas

"I'm protecting the story that I left for noble reasons. If that line disappears, I'm left with the truth — that I resigned because I was exhausted, ashamed of my failures, and afraid I couldn't keep going. Without the line, I have to face the collapse of the identity I built over twenty years."

What the line is protecting:

FIELD 3 The Scene Where It's Operating

Pick one scene you've already written where your character is talking, deciding, or reacting — a scene where you can now see they were delivering the line instead of living the truth underneath it. A line of dialogue that sounds too smooth. A decision that comes too easily.

EXAMPLE • Elena Vargas

SCENE: Elena tells a younger teacher, "I left because I couldn't stand by while the district ignored our students." The line sounds polished, almost rehearsed. The teacher nods. The scene feels too smooth.

IF SHE WEREN'T HIDING: "I left because I was tired, and I didn't know if I could keep fighting." That truth would shift the moment from a neat explanation to a vulnerable admission.

The scene (what happens, what they say):

If they weren't hiding, what would they say instead?

WHAT YOU HAVE NOW

A substrate sentence is a permanent asset. It doesn't just fix one scene — it applies to every scene this character appears in, for the rest of the novel. You're not done writing them. But you now know what every line they speak is quietly protecting, whether you write that protection in or leave it under the surface where the reader will feel it without being told.

IF A FIELD STALLED

That's normal — the first answer to any of these three prompts is almost always the rehearsed one, the version you'd give in an interview. The real answer tends to arrive on the third or fourth attempt, after you've refused to accept the first one. That refusal — held with patience, not force — is the entire mechanism behind the Stratum Socratic Writing Method.

Write Living Characters: A Fiction Writer's Masterclass teaches you to run that excavation with AI as your coach — asking the questions that get you past the first answer, on every character in your manuscript.